English Language practice paper 2: answers and marks

How to mark your paper. Question 1 is marked by ticking off the true statements. Questions 2, 3 and 4 are marked as a whole: read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best. Compare your answer with "What a top answer might say" and the list of things you could write about. You don't need all of them: two or three explained well beats a long list.

Write your mark next to each question, then add them up. Read the "Watch out" boxes even when you did well: they're the mistakes that cost people marks in the real exam.

Question 1

4 marks

Read again Source A from lines 1 to 15. Choose four statements below which are true. Choose a maximum of four statements.

- A Amira started secondary school with about eleven hundred other people.
- B Amira's new blazer fitted her perfectly.
- C Amira's timetable had been folded many times.
- D The school has two canteens.
- E Amira has already climbed the climbing wall.
- F Room 214 is next to room 213.
- G Amira walked into a Year 9 French lesson by mistake.
- H Amira met Maisie on her first morning.

The answer

A, C, D and G are true.

How the marks are given

- 1 mark for each true statement chosen, up to 4 marks.

Watch out

- Only use lines 1 to 15. Amira does try the climbing wall, but not until Friday (line 30), so E is false for lines 1 to 15.
- Choose only four. The question says a maximum of four.

Question 2

8 marks

You need to refer to Source A and Source B for this question. Use details from both sources. Write a summary of the differences between the food at Amira's school and the food at Edward's school.

What a top answer might say

The food at Amira's school is varied and modern: there is "a choice of pizza, pasta, curry or a 'build your own' wrap", which suggests the school cares what students like to eat. Edward has almost no choice: "bread and a thin porridge" and "for the most part" mutton, which suggests the food is cheap and the same every day. Amira's lunch is relaxed, as "Nobody makes you finish your vegetables", but Edward's boys must "eat every scrap in silence", which suggests strict rules even at mealtimes. Amira calls lunch "the best part of the day", while for Edward a pudding is so rare that he has "never been so grateful for anything", which shows how little he normally has to enjoy.

How the marks are given

This question is marked as a whole. Read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best.

7 to 8 marks	You pick out clear differences, and you say what each detail suggests (what you can work out from it, not just what it says). You use well-chosen quotes from both sources.
5 to 6 marks	You clearly explain differences, with relevant quotes from both sources, and start to say what the details suggest.
3 to 4 marks	You find some differences, with some quotes, but mostly say what the texts say rather than what it suggests.
1 to 2 marks	You give a simple difference, or write about only one source.
0 marks	Nothing relevant.

Things you could write about

- Choice: pizza, pasta, curry, wraps compared with bread, porridge and mutton
- Quality: Edward's mutton is "grey and tough" and the potatoes "have quite given up"
- Rules: "Nobody makes you finish your vegetables" compared with "eat every scrap in silence"
- How they pay or get it: thumbprint "like something out of a spy film" compared with being made to go without breakfast if late
- Enjoyment: "the best part of the day" compared with being grateful for one pudding

Watch out

- This is about what the details suggest, not how the writers write. Save language for Questions 3 and 4.
- Use both sources in every point, and say what each detail tells you.

Question 3

12 marks

You now need to refer only to Source B, lines 7 to 13. How does the writer use language to describe the school?

What a top answer might say

The writer makes the school sound cold, harsh and unwelcoming. "A great grey building upon a hill" makes it seem huge, gloomy and cut off, and the colour grey is dull and lifeless. The personification "the wind finds its way through every window" makes the cold seem like an intruder hunting the boys down. The detail of "thirty boys in two long rows of iron beds" sounds more like a prison or a barracks than a home, and "iron" sounds hard and cold. The water "skinned with ice" that they "must break... with our fists" is a shocking image, showing how tough life is. The phrase "woe betide" sounds old-fashioned and threatening, and the short final sentence, "I have not yet been late", shows Edward is frightened of the punishment.

How the marks are given

This question is marked as a whole. Read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best.

10 to 12 marks	You look closely at the writer's choices and explain their effects in detail. Your quotes are short and well chosen, and you use the right terms accurately.
7 to 9 marks	You clearly explain the effects of the writer's choices, with relevant quotes and some accurate terms.
4 to 6 marks	You try to say what effect the writer's choices have, with some quotes and some terms.
1 to 3 marks	You make simple comments, or spot a feature without saying what effect it has.
0 marks	Nothing written about the writer's language.

Things you could write about

- "a great grey building upon a hill": huge, gloomy, isolated
- Personification: "the wind finds its way through every window"
- "thirty boys in two long rows of iron beds": like a prison or barracks; "iron" is cold and hard
- "but one fire, which is never lit before November": cold, no comfort
- "skinned with ice", "break it with our fists": a harsh, physical image
- "woe betide": threatening; the bell rules their lives
- The short sentence "I have not yet been late": fear of punishment

Watch out

- Only use Source B, lines 7 to 13.
- Always explain the effect of the words. Naming a technique on its own gets very little.

Question 4

16 marks

For this question, you need to refer to the whole of Source A, together with the whole of Source B. Compare how the writers convey their different feelings about starting at a new school. In your answer, you could: compare their different feelings; compare the methods the writers use to convey their feelings; support your response with references to both texts.

What a top answer might say

Both writers feel nervous at first, but Amira ends up confident and happy, while Edward hides his unhappiness behind duty. Amira is honest about her feelings in a chatty, modern way: "I wanted the floor to swallow me up" and "I cried on Monday night". Edward is more formal and holds his feelings back: "I confess I have been colder this week than at any time in my life" is as close as he gets to complaining. Amira's school encourages her ("We're expecting you to try"), whereas Edward accepts harsh treatment, describing the cane without comment and deciding to "keep my copy-book clean". Both miss home: Amira misses the class hamster, and Edward thinks of "the kitchen fire" and his mother's voice. But Amira finishes on a proud, funny note, "not as small as I thought", while Edward finishes by trying to reassure his mother, "Please do not worry for me", which makes the reader worry for him even more.

How the marks are given

This question is marked as a whole. Read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best.

13 to 16 marks	You compare the writers' feelings in detail all the way through, and explain how each writer gets them across, with well-chosen quotes from both.
9 to 12 marks	You clearly compare their feelings and the methods they use, with relevant quotes from both sources.
5 to 8 marks	You make some comparisons and try to comment on methods, with some quotes.
1 to 4 marks	You make simple comments, or write about one source much more than the other.
0 marks	Nothing relevant.

Things you could write about

- Starting out: both nervous; Amira lost and embarrassed, Edward cold and homesick
- Tone: Amira's chatty, funny blog compared with Edward's formal, polite letter
- Honesty: Amira says she cried; Edward hides it ("I confess", "I will not pretend")
- The teachers: Mr Okafor's encouragement compared with Mr Hargreaves' cane
- Missing home: the class hamster compared with the kitchen fire and his mother's voice
- Endings: Amira proud and confident; Edward dutiful and brave, "as a gentleman should"

Watch out

- Compare all the way through, using words like whereas, but and both. Don't write about one source and then the other.
- Write about how they show their feelings (their methods), as well as what their feelings are.

Total: 40 marks. A rough guide for this practice paper: 30 or more is a strong result. 20 to 29 is solid, with some gaps to fix. Under 20 means going back over Paper 2 Questions 2 to 4 in the notebook first. Whatever you got, write down where you lost marks: that's what to revise next.